

Lesson 3 — Merchandise Planning Calendar

How a fashion retailer plans the season from product concept to final exit

What is a Merchandise Planning Calendar?

A merchandise planning calendar is a time-based roadmap that connects product development, buying, intake, sales, stock, markdowns and end-of-season exit. It helps the team make decisions early enough for the stock to be available when customers want it.

Think of it like a railway timetable: every activity has a planned date, and one delay can affect the activities that follow.

The typical fashion retail flow

Trend & customer insight → Range planning → Assortment → Buying → Vendor production → Inbound → Store / online launch → Full-price selling → Replenishment → Markdown → EOSS / exit → Review

Key calendar stages

1. Season strategy

Define the season objective, customer, categories, price architecture and sales target.

2. Range and assortment planning

Decide styles, options, colours, sizes and depth by category/channel.

3. Buying and order placement

Convert the plan into supplier orders and confirm lead times.

4. Production and inbound

Track production, quality, dispatch, transit, warehouse receipt and allocation.

5. Launch

Ensure stock is available before the planned customer demand peak.

6. Trading and replenishment

Monitor sales, ROS, WOS, sell-through, stock-outs and replenishment.

7. Markdown and exit

Plan markdown windows, clearance actions and residual stock exit.

8. Post-season review

Compare plan versus actual sales, margin, stock and inventory productivity.

Illustrative 26-week season

Period	Activity	Planning focus
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Weeks 1–4	Strategy & range	Sales target, category mix, options, price points
Weeks 5–8	Buying & production	Orders, supplier capacity, lead times
Weeks 9–12	Inbound & launch	Receipts, allocation, launch readiness
Weeks 13–18	Full-price trading	Sales, ROS, WOS, replenishment
Weeks 19–22	Trading optimisation	Chase, rebalance, slow-stock actions
Weeks 23–26	Markdown & exit	Markdown, clearance, RTV / carry-forward review

Important planning rule

The calendar should be built backwards from the customer demand date. If a winter collection must be in stores by 1 November, the planner works backwards through launch readiness, warehouse receipt, transit, production, approval and order placement.

Simple exercise

Choose one category such as polos. Create a 26-week calendar with columns for planned sales, receipts, opening stock, closing stock, ROS and WOS. Mark the intended launch, replenishment and markdown weeks. Then compare the plan with actual trading each week.

Key takeaway

A merchandise calendar turns a seasonal strategy into a sequence of timed commercial actions. Good planning is not only about what to buy; it is also about when every decision must happen.